



Cabinet

Title: Independent Review of Wandsworth Council's response to the Fox House fire, Maysoule Road, Battersea

Paper No. 26-5

Date: 26th January 2026

Cabinet Member: Cllr Simon Hogg, Leader & Cllr Aydin Dikerdem, Cabinet Member for Housing

Details of Executive Director: Andrew Travers, Chief Executive

1. **Executive Summary**

- 1.1. On 10 September 2025, a major fire broke out at Fox House, a five-storey block of 37 flats in Battersea, displacing over 100 residents. The fire spread rapidly across the roof void, requiring 15 fire engines and 100 firefighters to bring it under control. No residents were injured, but significant property damage occurred, and people were left without homes. Bronze, Silver and Gold roles were activated overnight to respond. A Gold meeting was convened at 9:30am on 11th September and a Humanitarian Assistance Lead Officer (HALO) was appointed to lead on the psychosocial support response for residents, and a Community Assistance Centre was opened.
- 1.2. On 8th October the Community Assistance Centre closed, the Gold group stood down, and the response transitioned into recovery. Households were appointed a named worker to support them through the transition into permanent accommodation. A recovery co-ordination group is sitting with representation from Housing, Finance and Insurance, Communications, and Emergency Planning. This is chaired by the Executive Director for Change and Innovation and has been monitoring the transition for residents into permanent accommodation, the progress on site, finance tracking and insurance claims, communications and capturing learning.
- 1.3. The following is an independent report from Barry Quirk CBE PhD BSc FRGS, detailing the events of the night and reviewing Wandsworth Council's response to the fire. The review took place throughout November and December 2025, and consulted residents, emergency services, Councillors

and officers involved in the fire response.

1.4. Barry Quirk is an experienced former Chief Executive and qualified in housing management. In June 2017, he was drafted by Government and the LGA to support the response to the Grenfell Tower fire tragedy. He was appointed in September 2017 as Chief Executive of the Royal Borough of Kensington and Chelsea (RBKC) and worked to reshape the Council and the relationship with the thousands of bereaved, survivors and local communities that were impacted by the Grenfell tower fire.

1.5. As of publication of this report, all tenants of Fox House will have moved into new accommodation. Displaced residents impacted who were initially placed in a Travelodge, had all moved into their new accommodation prior to Christmas. The final resident moved into their new flat on 15th January 2026.

2. Recommendation/s:

2.1. Cabinet are requested to note the report and its recommendations and agree the actions set out below.

3. Details

3.1. In summary, Barry Quirk's Independent Review commends Wandsworth Council for its strong response to the Fox House fire, highlighting examples of good practice such as the effective use of data. However, the report also identifies areas for improvement, particularly in the initial hours of the response.

3.2. His recommendations are set out below alongside the Council's actions to address them.

Recommendation	Action	Lead	Deadline
Organisational leadership and Gold/Silver/Bronze			
Strengthen and formalise the Gold, Silver and Bronze arrangements. Adopt the appropriate involvement of Members of the political executive and local ward councillors.	Plans to increase and strengthen the Gold and Silver rotas were in place before the fire and have since been implemented. Briefing arrangements for members are already embedded into Gold.	Assistant Chief Executive	July 2026

	Explore where members can be included in exercising, such as the annual corporate exercise.		
Ensure that a senior director with delegated authority to commit resources is physically on site within two hours of a major incident being declared.	Ensure that Council Silvers are aware they can, and should, attend site if the situation requires it, i.e. a major incident is declared.	Assistant Chief Executive	31/03/2026
Make explicit, and routinely brief on, the protocols for decision-making, escalation and governance.	Ensure staff across all services engage with the training already available. Reinforce response roles in training. Consider what additional training can be made available.	Assistant Chief Executive	30/09/2026
Operational readiness and systems			
Review “grab bag” arrangements for the essential materials needed by onsite staff (phones, chargers, preset household identification reports, etc).	Prepare emergency centre equipment boxes to be collected with the keys. Review and replenish sleeping and welfare equipment in existing stores. Review equipment used by the Local Authority Liaison Officer (LALO) on site.	Assistant Chief Executive	28/02/2026
Ensure that control of all key contractors and commissioned providers are visible to on-site management as well as to those operating in	Reinforce in training for all roles that the LALO is in control of resources at the scene of an incident, and any staff or contractors working on	Assistant Chief Executive	30/06/2026

Gold, Silver, Bronze and LALO roles.	our behalf should report to them. Include emergency protocols in contracts and letters of engagement?		
Review the current arrangements with ICAB	Other providers to be considered in comparison. Agree guidance/thresholds for reverting to alternative arrangements than placing in hotels e.g. setting up sleeping equipment.	Executive Director, Resident Services	31/03/2026
Residents, humanitarian support and members			
Embed a consistently corporate and humanitarian approach in all incidents.	Review and update all Humanitarian Assistance guidance to incorporate learning from this incident.	Executive Director, Adult Social Care and Public Health	30/06/2026
Train and develop managers and staff to operate in fully corporate responses, including joint training and exercising with statutory partners and voluntary sector organisations.	Ensure staff across all services engage with the training already available. Explore options for a trained 'surge capacity' pool of staff that can respond where needed.	Assistant Chief Executive	30/09/2026
Provide dedicated training and guidance for councillors, in line with the updated LGA councillors' guide to civil resilience.	Training based on the updated LGA guidance will be included in member induction post local elections.	Assistant Chief Executive	31/07/2026
Technical learning and building safety			
Seek further expert advice on both the cause of the fire and the rapid spread within the roof	Continue to work to provide safe access for fire investigators.	Executive Director, Resident Services	

space, and on the full range of feasible remedial and rectification works across Fox House and similar blocks, drawing on specialist fire engineering, architectural and surveying expertise.	Work is underway on the sibling blocks to address findings from fire risk inspections. Future work to be directed by investigation findings.		
Work jointly across housing, building control and relevant external experts to design and deliver a programme of diagnostic inspections of roof voids and other communal voids, and to oversee any remedial works required.	Engage specialist contractors to carry out inspections. Future work to be directed by investigation findings.	Executive Director, Resident Services	
When appropriate, issue notifications and share learning with other building owners, landlords and professional bodies.	Share learning from the response with other local authorities across London through Emergency Planning channels.	Executive Director, Resident Services	10/09/2026

Reference to any accompanying papers: Barry Quirk - Independent Review of Wandsworth Council's response to the Fox House fire, Maysoule Road, Battersea